

When the Pioneers began to win, the fans began to come out. The team caught on like no other, Elmira team had in the 12 seasons before.

An early September doubleheader attracted 6,500 fans to the park — Then the biggest paid crowd ever to watch an Elmira pro baseball team.

It was Depression time, but one wouldn't know it by the attendance during the thrill-a-game 1936 season. The Elmira officials had lured Walter Maranville to take the job of manager for 1936. The colorful Rabbit and his mates attracted more than 100,000 paid into Dunn Field — almost double any previous season attendance and one-quarter of the entire eight-team league's gate for the year.

Professional baseball was in the glory days. The Elmira group sold the franchise to Brooklyn during the 1936-37 winter. The Dodgers provided first division talent, and the fans flocked to the park.

Things cooled considerably between Elmira and Brooklyn owner Larry MacPhail in July 1940. Elmira fans blew sky high when MacPhail pulled out .379-hitting Pete Reiser and 12-game winner Ed Head.

Fans stopped going to the park. MacPhail was so incensed that he pulled out the Dodgers after the 1940 season and gave Elmira back its franchise for a token fee.

It was "save baseball" time again. The local group found Johnny Ogden, a long-time baseball man. They sold him the franchise with no return clause if Ogden decided to get out.

Ogden did a real sales job locally and he produced.

Although he worked basically alone, Ogden managed to hook up-in a talent pool deal with the Buffalo Bisons of the International League.

Johnny bought such as Andy Cohen, Alex Monchak, Ray Roche, Frank Madura, Sammy Holbrook and Willie Duke. These acquisitions jelled almost immediately with the three big prospects provided by the Bisons—Sal Maglie, Eddie Robinson and Eddie Kobesky.

The Pioneers were near the top all season, and Ogden reportedly made a bundle as the team attracted 124,384 fans.

That success didn't last. Ogden's magic didn't work at all in 1942. The team was poor, finishing sixth, and attendance tumbled to 61,035.

That was it for Ogden. He quit as an operator, and instead of awaiting a reply from Elmiraans on

their option to buy the franchise, he sold out to Utica interests. Elmira was back in he "save baseball" business.

This time Lande and Co. urged Jim McKinnon to head a local independent operation which would raise money to buy a franchise if one became available for the Eastern League.

Elmira's hopes were dim for a long time. Then the Williamsport franchise became available, and McKinnon was quick to take it. Once again, the local group hit the jackpot.

Connie Mack (Philadelphia A's) and Bill DeWitt (St. Louis Browns) agreed to send players to Elmira. It was a bonanza.

Sam Zoldak and Alex Mustakis formed Elmira's only dual 20-game winners in a single season, and Don Smith, Barney Lutz, Edgar Bush and Les Moss were .300 hitters. The Pioneers finished second, won the Governor's Cup and attracted the highest paid crowd in Elmira history (8,700) to a playoff game with Scranton. The team drew 165,000 fans during a war year.

The Pioneers' baseball boat once again was back on keel, and once again the highly successful local group decided to let a major league club handle the show. The franchise was sold to the St. Louis Browns after the 1943 season.

The Brownies stayed here through the 1949 season — six years of second division finishes and only fair rates.

After 1949 it was crisis again. St. Louis sold the franchise back to Elmira for the \$7,500 it paid in 1943 and the search was on once again for a supplier of talent, someone to "save" baseball.

Just as he had done 20 years earlier, Branch Rickey came to the rescue.

Rickey had left the Cards and had built the Dodgers into a powerhouse. He always had a soft spot in his heart for Elmira, so he decided to purchase the franchise and operate it on an ownership basis.

This time the Dodgers stayed six years, through the 1955 season. They had great teams in 1951 and

1954 and a tremendously popular promotor in 1951 — Spencer Harris.

Harris, like Ogden in 1941 and the Rabbit in 1936, sold Pioneer baseball everywhere.

The 1951 Pioneers attracted a record 126,000 during the season and averaged 6,500 for four playoff games at Dunn Field for an overall gate of 152,000.

By 1954, though, fans had turned to other things. And even though Elmira had Tommy Holmes as manager and Clyde Parris as batting champion, the Pioneers couldn't come close to those 1951 figures. Brooklyn blamed poor attendance and a poor press in leaving after the 1955 season.

The Dodgers sold the franchise back to Elmira interests for the \$7,500 they paid in 1950. Once more an angel was needed to "save" Elmira baseball.

This time Elmiraans acted too hastily. They sold the franchise without strings attached to long-time Scranton baseball man Joe Reardon.

Reardon couldn't get anything going. Before anyone knew what was happening, he set up shop in Syracuse with the Elmira franchise in 1956.

Elmira was out of professional baseball. A group headed by Packy Rogers and Alan Gould came forward to organize a hot-shot semi-pro club which averaged 800 fans a game and had a 35-1 record for the 1956 season. It was the forerunner of Elmira's return to the pro wars in 1957.

This time, though, it was Class D New York - Penn League caliber instead of Class A Eastern.

The New York Giants (Carl Hubbel and Co.) came into Elmira in September 1956 with a franchise for Elmira in the Eastern League, after an enthusiastic meeting with businessmen and baseball officials at the Mark Twain Hotel, things looked great.

The next day the New York Giants officials were fogged into Elmira, when they finally got out, they were so unhappy that they gave the franchise to Springfield, Mass., instead.

Anyway, Elmira hooked up with Sherry Robertson and the Washington Senators for a Class D club in the NY-P in 1957.

It was miserable. The team played poorly, and there was loud talk of player dissension in mid-season. The Senators stayed around through another dismal 1958 season. Then disgusted Elmira officials, heeding fan complaints, looked around for another tie-up.

The Philadelphia Phils provided the answer.

The Phils came in for three years (1959-61) and gave Elmira exciting Class D teams. But fans simply didn't cotton to it. Gates were poor. So was management.

After the 1961 season a local group, headed by Art Wellington, set its sights on a return to the Eastern League.

A franchise was available, and contact was made with Harry Dalton of the Baltimore Orioles. A few meetings later, Elmira was back in Class A with a 10-gallon hat promoter in Ward Goodrich and a banty rooster manager in Earl Weaver.



THE SCENE: Elmira, N.Y., Aug. 13, 1972 3

